



Gendered organizations and intersectionality: problems and possibilities

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Abstract

Purpose – Theorizing that was conceived in the 1970s about gendered processes in organizations helped explain gender inequalities in organizations. This article aims to take the opportunity to re-examine these processes – including the gendered substructure of organizations, gendered subtext, the gendered logic of organization and the abstract worker from the perspective of the original author in a present-day context.

Design/methodology/approach – A reflexive approach was used to consider how gender theorizing itself has become more complex as captured in the notion of intersectionality when gender process interacts with other forms of inequality.

Findings – The key finding is the persistence of inequality regimes despite organizational changes, which still make developments in theorizing gender processes relevant.

Originality/value – This article is an opportunity to reflect on the conceptualization and development of one's theorizing over three decades, which has suggested that there are still key questions that demand answers from academics and practitioners who want to challenge these inequality regimes.

Keywords Gender, Organizational structures, Equality, Equal opportunities

Paper type Research paper

Theorizing gender and organizations began in the late 1960s and early 1970s as feminist scholars criticized conventional organizational research as inadequate because it ignores the importance of gender in working life (e.g. Acker and Van Houten, 1974; Kanter, 1977). Since then, scholars have done a great deal of research on gender processes in organizations, created new concepts, including “gendered” and “gendering,” and greatly increased knowledge about how gender inequalities are produced and reproduced. But, a number of issues about how to think about gender inequalities remain unresolved. New questions will undoubtedly keep challenging this field because the empirical terrain is constantly changing. In addition, theorizing gender has become much more complicated because of “intersectionality,” the idea that gendered processes do not stand alone, but intersect with and are shaped by race and class processes, as well as other forms of inequality and exclusion. The papers in this issue of EDI deal with issues about theorizing gender and with issues about intersectionality, as well as with questions about how to use this conceptual approach in doing research. I will outline how I presently think about these dilemmas and discuss briefly some of the challenges to researchers in this field arising from changes in economies, technologies, the organization of work and production, and the dominance of neo-liberal market ideologies. The examples I use are primarily from research in the US. Research from other fairly successful capitalist countries seems to show similar, but not identical patterns.



Some dilemmas in conceptualizing gender in organizing

Two dilemmas stand out as important in the papers in this issue of *EDI*:

- (1) how to best conceptualize the gendering of organizations; and
- (2) how to conceptualize “intersectionality.”

The notion of a gendered substructure of organizations is a way to begin to answer the persistent question: why do gender inequalities, including the gap between women’s and men’s pay and the sex segregation of jobs (IWPR, 2011), survive in spite of powerful women’s movements, laws mandating equality, massive movement of women into the paid labor force, and the achievement of gender equality in college graduation? “Gendered Substructure” points to often-invisible processes in the ordinary lives of organizations in which gendered assumptions about women and men, femininity and masculinity, are embedded and reproduced, and gender inequalities perpetuated. The most common inequalities are the wage gap between women and men and the sex segregation of jobs, occupations, and hierarchical positions. These inequalities have been reduced, but are still widespread. Huge variation exists between organizations and across time and national contexts. Many of the articles in this issue of *EDI* discuss the concept of a gendered substructure. Other concepts play a part in discussions of the gendered substructure, most importantly, gendered subtext, gendered organizational logic, and the “ideal worker”. Here I offer my present understanding of these ideas, arguing that we can distinguish between these concepts and use them to develop a complex analysis. I begin with a summary of the components of the gendered substructure and a discussion of how ideas of a gendered subtext, a gendered logic of organization, and of the abstract worker are related to each other and to the gendered substructure.

Gendered substructures

Organizing processes. The gendered substructure is created in the organizing processes in which inequalities are built into job design, wage determination, distribution of decision-making and supervisory power, the physical design of the work place, and rules, both explicit and implicit, for behavior at work[1]. Research I did in the 1980s on comparable worth (Acker, 1989) provides an example of how a design of a wage setting system produced a gendered wage gap. The state of Oregon had a job classification system which was the basis for wage determination. Particular jobs were placed in a classification: each classification was placed in a wage category. Lower level staff worked in jobs that were sex segregated. Women’s jobs were described in general terms and grouped into a few classifications with low wage ranges. Men’s jobs were described in more specific terms and grouped in many more classifications with a greater range of wages. As a result of classification and grouping of jobs, women’s jobs were on average paid less than men’s jobs. Gender entered this system directly in attributing more value to jobs with material or physical tasks than to jobs with people caring tasks. Groundskeepers (men) were paid more than day care workers (women). To understand this example more fully, we would have to trace the process of the creation of the classification system and the assignment of wage ranges to wage categories. Who did it? What were they thinking? Did they recognize that they were treating men’s jobs and women’s jobs differently? However, just looking at how this bureaucratic system functioned and its outcomes helps us (me) see how hidden some of

the inequality processes are, hidden in plain sight in classification and wage category schemes that can look gender neutral and abstract.

Organization culture. The gendered substructure is also created in the particular organization's culture, including beliefs about gender differences and equality/inequality. As in the above example, unexamined beliefs about gender difference may shape ostensibly gender-neutral bureaucratic practices. Organization culture is the sum of particular, often time and place specific, images, attitudes, beliefs, behaviors and values. These may be shared with many other organizations, but may also be specific for one or a few. The culture usually includes definitions of gendered behaviors, both acceptable and unacceptable, and images of multiple masculinities and femininities. In many organizations, employees believe that equality exists when measures of wage differences and segregation, for example, indicate that equality is far from a reality. Thus, a culture of denial and invisibility of inequities perpetuates the inequities. These cultural processes support the continuation of structuring practices that produce inequities and often undermine attempts at organizational change. The culture of a particular organization is, of course, located in the larger cultural terrain of the surrounding society. However, today's societies often contain more than one cultural perspective on race, gender, and class relations. In addition, organizational subunits may have different cultures of inequality.

Interactions on the job. The gendered substructure is also produced and reproduced in interactions on the job between colleagues and between those at different levels of power: they may be person-to-person or they may occur in group settings, both formal and informal. Such interactions may reinforce equality, but they are often the site of affirmation of inequality. Interactions may belittle or exclude women, particularly in male dominated groups. Sexuality may complicate working relations. Whether it is exploitative or consensual, just joking or harassing, sexuality is a clear confirmation of gender difference that complicates efforts to achieve gender equality. Some of the more gross forms of sexism in interactions at work may have disappeared, but it may go underground and reappear, for example, as opposition to proposals favored by women or seemingly objective criticisms of women's abilities to do the job.

Gendered identities. Finally, the gender substructure includes individual gendered identities, constructed in the work place, but also brought with the individual into the organization. What does it mean to be a man or a woman? How does a man or a woman act on the job? Gender identities are formed and changed as women and men participate in the work processes that produce other aspects of the gender substructure. Again, great variation exists and gendered identities may be modified with experience. Women in professional or upper managerial positions may face difficult pressures to "manage like a man" (Wacjman, 1998). But managing like a man may bring other pressures, a double bind: the woman who is aggressive and competitive, like a stereotypical man, may be seen as too assertive, even bitchy, but if she behaves in a more feminine and cooperative manner she may be seen as soft and ineffective (Pierce, 1995). Challenges to the male manager model have emerged, with the argument that a more feminine model of an empathetic, supportive manager represents a better manager (Billing, 2011). Managers' identities are complex, variable, and changing over time and place.

All of the components of the gender substructure are aspects of ongoing organizing processes: for example, wage setting, a bureaucratic practice, involves cultural

assumptions about gender differences in various capacities as well as assumptions about the value of those capacities. Such assumptions are often implicit in wage decisions, brought into play in the interactions between those with wage setting responsibilities. Individual identities also influence those interactions and the outcomes of the process. Thus, the concept of gendered substructure and the ongoing processes that produce and reproduce it is very broad, and includes many, always interacting, aspects of organizing.

Gendered subtext

The notion of a gender subtext is sometimes used in a way that is very similar to my idea of a gendered substructure. I see the gender subtext as part of the gendered substructure, but not its totality. To differentiate “gender subtext” from gendered substructure, I use the concept to refer to texts, explicit or implicit, written or just common practice, that shape the gendered, processes and structures. For example, a job evaluation system, as used in the comparable worth study in the state of Oregon, briefly discussed above, (Acker, 1989), was a complicated text with instructions for describing job content, always presented as gender neutral. Job evaluation consisted of careful description of job content and comparison with other jobs. Only certain jobs could be compared with certain other jobs. For example, the job of a manager could not be compared with the job of a secretary. Thus, if the secretary was actually doing management tasks, as sometimes happened, this could never become part of a score comparing the manager to the secretary. The two were never compared. Because most managers were men, and all secretaries were women, this rule in the evaluation text had a gendered effect. The existing pay gap between the manager and the secretary could not be reduced, according to the ways that the rules worked. This is not surprising: the evaluation scheme was developed by organizational consultants with the advice of corporate managers. Policies, guides, memos and other texts shape many other organizing functions and potentially contribute to the reproduction of gendered work places.

Organizational logic

Organizational logic is an element in the gendered subtext, as discussed above. I see this idea as referring to common understandings about how organizations are put together, the constituent parts, how the whole thing works. Originally, I thought about organizational logic as the logic of bureaucracy and hierarchy. Departments with defined responsibilities, arranged in hierarchies of resources, power and control, each higher level helping to coordinate the collective functions. At each level, men tend to have the higher-level positions. Women are in lower-level positions and in staff, not line, positions. Now, times have changed and women are about half of those in jobs categorized as “management,” but in many bureaucracies, management jobs are differentiated in ways that tend to preserve some sex segregation. Other organizational forms with other logics exist. For example, team-based organization has a different logic, one of democratic collaboration rather than hierarchical control. However, team-based organization may or may not produce greater gender equality (e.g. Vallas, 2003; Kvande and Rasmussen, 1994). Organizational logics are created and transmitted through texts, management consultants, articles in management journals, books, lectures in management schools and departments, and schools of public policy.

The gender neutral, abstract worker

The gendered logic of organization includes the widespread understanding that jobs usually come with certain expectations for worker behavior: arrive at work at a specified time; take breaks for lunch at certain times and for an agreed upon length of time; do the work assigned to you; the work has your undivided attention; you stay on the job for a specific number of hours. These rules appear to be gender neutral, but they are not. As I have argued elsewhere (Acker, 2006a, 2006b), they are implicitly built on the image of a gender neutral, abstract worker who has no body and no obligations outside the work place: this worker is unencumbered. The gender neutral, abstract worker is much like the "individual" in classical theory of the social contract (Pateman, 1988). Men are more likely than women to be able to conform to the ideal of the abstract worker. This is part of the gendered subtext of organizations as well as organizational logic. It implicitly differentiates women from men, with men more likely to be seen as real workers, because traditionally women have done the unpaid work that allows men to be unencumbered. Employers may be reluctant to hire women for jobs, usually male dominated and defined, in which the worker is expected to be unencumbered. This reluctance may be important in the continuing sex segregation of jobs (Iversen and Rosenbluth, 2010).

The ideal, abstract worker is only part of what employers seek when they are hiring: employers, of course, have specific qualifications in mind, such as education, experience in particular fields, evidence of competence, etc. The real life ideal worker for a nursing home job would have very different qualifications than a real life ideal worker for a skilled construction job. Prospective employers would probably prefer that both would be as unencumbered as the abstract worker.

The gendered subtext and logics of organizations, with their implicit beliefs in essential differences between women and men, that women are nurturing, caring, and gentle while men are active, competitive, and good with tools and machines, have strong foundations in the basic structuring of work in capitalist societies. Work, including paid and unpaid, is divided by gender. Paid work is located in organizations that are radically separated from the location of most unpaid work, the home. The home is ideologically the domain of women, the place where they care for babies and raise the children, generally taking care of the needs of others. "Work" is ideologically the domain of men, where they make money and build the larger society, engaging in competitive struggles. These are simplified stereotypes that hardly represent reality today. But, the separation of domains is still stark and enduring, and, I believe, gives continual life to beliefs about differences between women and men. The two domains are not only radically separated in time and place, they also have different goals and different forms of organization. Work organizations in capitalist societies aim, in the majority of cases, to produce a profit. Public sector organizations often mimic the private sector, under the influence of the dominant neo-liberal ideology. Such organizations have no responsibility for the reproduction of people: that responsibility lies in the domestic sector, which, of course, depends on wages from the production for profit sector, supplemented in varying degrees by state programs. All this is not news, nor is the recognition that women are the primary workers in the unpaid sector.

Thus, the radical, structural separation of production and reproduction perpetuates deeply embedded images of femininity and masculinity, affecting the work place processes and ordinary decision making that perpetuates gender differentiation and inequality.

In summary: the gendered substructure of organizations consists of processes and practices of organizing that continually recreate gender inequalities. These processes and practices are supported by organizational cultures and reproduced in interactions on the job, shaped in part by the gendered self-images of participants. These gendering processes are, at a less visible level, supported by gender subtexts of organizing and a gendered logic of organization that link the persistence of gender divisions to the fundamental organization of capitalist societies.

Intersectionality

The analysis of gender outlined above is incomplete because it ignores racial and class processes that are also essential elements in the ongoing reproduction of inequalities. The concept of intersectionality is a way to conceptualize the complex interweaving of analytically separated processes. I have discussed in earlier publications some of the problems and complexities of this concept, as have many others, and suggested some ways to conceptualize intersectionality to solve these problems (e.g. Acker, 2006a, 2006b), as have others (e.g. Britton and Logan, 2008; Choo and Ferree, 2010; Knapp, 2005). Here I suggest some additions to my proposals to study inequality regimes as a solution to the problems with intersectionality.

The concept of gendering processes, as discussed above, could be expanded to combine it with racializing and class creating processes. Racial definitions, exclusions and inclusions, are created in the same organizing processes that also create and recreate gender inclusions and exclusions, resulting in a much more complicated picture of differences and inequities. For example, hiring practices might be based on assumptions about racial identities as well as gender identities. Interactions at work may be shaped by racial stereotyping as well as gender and class stereotyping.

Race and class are anchored in subtexts that are somewhat different from the gender subtext, although the race and class subtexts can also be traced to the historical development of capitalism. In the US underlying white assumptions about race have origins in slavery, genocide of original populations, and wars of expansion, particularly the war against Spanish/Mexicans. These political and violent acts were often justified by assumptions of white superiority. Although this history is almost invisible in the society, the assumption of white superiority is still strong. The underlying subtext supporting the legitimacy and inevitability of class inequality lies in the American beliefs in individual independence, hard work, and the opportunity for success. Neoliberal economic theory reinforces these ideas, as it focuses on individual responsibility, the obligation to work for pay, the superiority of the market, and the elimination of state-provided supports for families and individuals (Morgen *et al.*, 2010). Class inequality in work organizations is relatively invisible, hidden in “management” and “bureaucracy” discourses. It is also widely accepted, as just the way things are. Class processes and hierarchies are always gendered and racialized (Acker, 2006a). Class comes into organizations in another way, in the pre-existing class identities of organization participants. Class-linked individual identities should be examined as a separate factor in inequality regimes.

Researching intersectionality

Intersectionality can be conceptualized in different ways and examined empirically with different methodologies (Choo and Ferree, 2010). The idea of inequality regimes is

only one possible approach. It requires the analysis of processes simultaneously embedding gender, race, and class images and assumptions in ongoing practical activities. It can be used as a tool for description of particular organizations at particular historical moments, compared with other organizations or compared with other historical moments. It can also be used to help answer research questions such as, for example, how is a particular pattern of sex/race/segregation reproduced in a particular organization or why did a policy to increase equality fail? Or succeed? This approach can result in very complex, unwieldy, research processes. However, strategic decisions can be made to focus research on only certain aspects of inequality regimes to answer particular questions. Such decisions can simplify a research endeavor, but always at the risk of *a priori* eliminating something that later proves to be important.

I believe that studies that answer questions about how intersectionality actually works to produce inequalities are most revealing when done with an ethnographic or case study methodology[2]. I used this method when looking at gender in local branches of two large Swedish banks (Acker, 1991, 1994). The purpose of the study was to see if certain organizational changes were reducing sex segregation and the gender pay gap in these banks. My experience with this study as well as a study of welfare department branches in Oregon (Morgen *et al.*, 2010) also convinced me that another essential component in studying inequality on the ground is to use research questions that clearly relate to the intersections of gender, race, and class. Without such an *a priori* focus, the least visible manifestations of class, race, and gender processes may remain invisible. Most research on inequality in organizations focuses on only one inequality process: studies that look at several simultaneously are rare (but see Pierce, 1995). As organizations and occupations change in uncertain economic conditions and growing class inequality, the gendered and racialized processes in organizations may be changing too, suggesting new questions about inequality regimes. In the following I briefly review economic and organizing changes and speculate about the research possibilities presented by these developments, finally suggesting policy changes that could reduce the present growing inequalities.

The possible futures of gender, race, and class in organizations

Economic and organizational changes

Many changes in the shape and degree of societal wide inequality have occurred since feminist sociologists started talking about and researching gender inequalities. These changes have also shaped new patterns of racial and class inequality. Organizations' inequality regimes changed in some visible and important ways in the 1960s and 1970s. New legislation and Affirmative Action programs (Reskin, 1998) changed many hiring and promotion policies, and the civil rights and women's movements gave powerful support to increasing equality both inside and outside of work organizations. Today, because of equality policies and increasing demand for female labor, women work for wages in much larger proportions than 40 years ago. But, wages have risen very little since the 1970s: most men are no longer the sole source of family support. For most people, the "family wage" is gone. By the 1980s, reduction of race and gender inequalities began to slow, as structures of the world of work were changing. Production and distribution of products and services changed significantly as new organizing processes, new types of jobs, and new technology were introduced. Work organizations began to reduce the costs of operation with many strategies to hold

wages steady or to reduce them: downsizing, substituting new technology for workers, outsourcing, moving jobs to low wage countries, or transforming some jobs into contingent work. Now, in 2011, with high unemployment and stagnant wages, economic survival is often problematic. And inequalities between those at the top of the income hierarchy and everyone else are at record levels. In this discouraging picture, what has happened to inequality regimes?

In 2011, inequality regimes seem to be relatively resistant to additional change. Affirmative Action, which made a difference for white women and people of color, is still alive, but not well: diversity programs have so far had a spotty record of success. More white women and more women and men from non-white categories have found places in middle management and the professions in both private and public sectors. However, white men are still clearly the dominant category in the top positions in almost all organizations. The gender wage gap has decreased but is still there within and between occupations and within and between layers of hierarchy in organizations (IWPR, 2011). This is also still true of racial inequalities in earnings. Gendering and racialization are still occurring, although these processes are, in my view, more invisible than before. Most White people do not want to be called racists; many men do not want to be accused of sexism. And almost no one talks about class.

I see little evidence that hiring, wage setting, promotion and other processes have changed much in recent years to eliminate racialized and gendered substructures. The under lying images of the unencumbered worker have, if anything, become more extreme with expectations that the worker will spend the time it takes to finish the job, even if that is almost 24/7. Of course, that does not represent all jobs: some low wage jobs are structured as part time, partly to avoid any obligations on the part of the employer to pay for any benefits.

This pessimistic assessment is partially caused by the unemployment crisis in the US at the time of this writing, in May 2011. The politics of crisis at this moment do not take unemployment and inequality seriously. A change in those politics toward efforts to deal with inequalities and unemployment might open possibilities for efforts to change the underlying processes that keep reproducing such inequities. It may take a much larger, more painful crisis to move politics in that direction. In the meantime, researchers can discover more about the complexity and variety of inequality regimes in the context of contemporary changes.

Questions about gender, race, and class in changing economies

A number of researchable questions arise when we look at organizational changes that may alter inequality regimes:

- (1) What counts as “an organization”? Within what boundaries do we focus investigation? Are the locations of outsourced functions part of the original organization or a different organization? In some cases, new organizations in different countries are established specifically to service the home organization. For example, recent news stories discussed the very low wages and miserable working conditions in the Chinese factories that produce the Apple iPad and iPhones (Chamberlain, 2011). These factories seem to produce only for Apple. Is Apple an employer that exploits young women workers or not? How can its inequality regime(s) be described?

- (2) What jobs constitute the workforce of a particular employer? Does it include contingent, contract, temporary, and part time workers? Does it include all levels of employees, from the top to the bottom? This makes a difference in a description of an inequality regime. For example, many studies of higher education organizations focus only on the core professional levels, usually producing a picture of decreased gender and race inequality. But this picture is much more positive than a picture that included contingent and peripheral staff along with comparisons of their situations with those of faculty and top administrators.
- (3) Have organizational logics changed with new forms of employment and new types of dispersed organization? How do these logics deal, or not deal with gender, race, and class inequities?
- (4) Have new technologies of wage setting, supervision, and accountability been developed to deal with new forms of organization and new types of employment? If so, what implications do these new technologies have for race, gender, and class equality?
- (5) Do new or strengthened ideologies of masculinity and femininity support changing organizations and proliferating forms of employment? Specifically, do media images of aggressive, competitive masculinity support organizational and employment changes?
- (6) How can organizations increase the visibility of underlying class, gender, and race stereotypes?
- (7) Do the new forms of employments offer possibilities of bridging the gaps between paid and unpaid work?

Some policy proposals

The underlying schism between the paid work sector and the unpaid (domestic) work sector is a fundamental structure of capitalism and one of the most enduring gender, race and class substructures because it is critical in the reproduction of the masculine and the feminine. I find it impossible to imagine how this could be changed within capitalism or what a different system would look like. However, state measures to ameliorate the negative consequences of this division are possible and have been either partially or fully implemented in various countries. Such measures include ample, paid parental leave and widely available, low cost childcare services. These exist in Scandinavia and some other countries. Wages for stay-at-home parents could be a partial solution and paid parental leave is a move in that direction. A guaranteed, universal annual income, allowing people to work or not to work in the wage sector is another partial solution (Patemen, 2004), but a total fantasy under present economic and political conditions. Another solution, which again leaves the underlying structures unchanged, is to get men to fully accept responsibility for one half of all unpaid domestic and family tasks. While men have taken up more of certain unpaid tasks, there is little evidence that gender equality in unpaid domestic labor will be achieved in any imaginable future (Charles and Grusky, 2004). In the present economic crisis, unemployed men with working (for pay) wives may do more childcare and housework, but this probably won't continue as male unemployment drops. I see two reasons for this: male earnings are still, on the whole, higher than female earnings

(IWPR, 2011), and a positive masculine self image usually includes the ability to earn an adequate income. Popular images of desirable masculinity do not yet include men as primary homemakers.

Notes

1. In this discussion I use the concept “processes” to refer to the interconnecting flow of “practices” or the concrete practical activities that constitute an organization.
2. For an interesting example of detailed racial processes, see Pierce (2003).

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Further reading

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